

# A home World Cup and an unfinished story

Aditya Padinjat

aditya.p@thehindu.co.in

It has been 32 years since the USA last hosted a FIFA World Cup. The USMNT reached the Round of 16 in 1994, and it heads into the 2026 edition with genuine optimism as it looks to better that performance on home soil.

Having established itself as a regular presence on international football's biggest stage, the Stars and Stripes signalled their ambition to compete more seriously among the elite with the appointment of Mauricio Pochettino to replace Gregg Berhalter.

Pochettino, who boasts experience at the highest level of the European club

game with Tottenham Hotspur, Chelsea and Paris Saint-Germain, has been tasked with making the USA more competitive against the world's best while introducing a more dynamic style of play.

Its expectations, however, will be tempered by comprehensive friendly defeats to Portugal and Belgium during the last international break, a reminder of the ground Pochettino and Co. still have to make up.

He has a youthful and exciting player pool to support his ambitions. While AC Milan winger Christian Pulisic has long been the lynchpin of this side, Folarin Balogun, Weston McKennie, Timothy



## USA

**FIFA Ranking:** 16

**Appearances:** 11

**Best finish:** Semifinals (1930)

**Matches:** 37

**Wins:** 9

**Draws:** 8

**Losses:** 20

**Goals For:** 40

**Goals Against:** 66

**Highest scorer in the squad**  
Christian Pulisic (33 goals)



## TURKIYE

**FIFA Ranking:** 22

**Appearances:** 2

**Best finish:** Third place (2002)

**Matches:** 10

**Wins:** 5

**Draws:** 1

**Losses:** 4

**Goals For:** 20

**Goals Against:** 17

**Highest scorer in the squad**  
Hakan Calhanoglu (22 goals)

